



Eritrea



Lying along the southwest shore of the Red Sea, Eritrea won a long war for independence from Ethiopia in 1993. The two neighbors fought a bitter border war in 1998–2000.



GEOGRAPHY

Mostly consists of rugged mountains, bush, and the Danakil Desert, which falls below sea level.



CLIMATE

Warm in the mountains; desert areas are hot. Droughts from July onward are common.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Tigrinya-speakers, mainly Orthodox Christians, are the most numerous of nine main ethnic groups. A strong sense of nationhood has been forged by war. Women played a vital role in combat. Over 80% of people are subsistence farmers. Multiparty elections, expected since 1997, have been persistently postponed.



INSIGHT: *Eritrea is the only country to secede successfully in postcolonial Africa*



THE ECONOMY

Legacy of disruption and destruction from wars; resettlement of refugees. Susceptible to drought and famine: dependent on food aid. Most of the population live at subsistence level. Potential for extraction of gold, copper, and oil. Red Sea location: port at Massawa.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: State of Eritrea

DATE OF FORMATION: 1993

CAPITAL: Asmara

POPULATION: 5.07 million

TOTAL AREA: 46,842 sq. miles
(121,320 sq. km)

DENSITY: 112 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Tigrinya*, English*, Tigre, Afar, Arabic*, Bilen, Kunama, other

RELIGIONS: Christian 45%, Muslim 45%, other 10%

ETHNIC MIX: Tigray 50%, Tigre 31%, other 9%, Saho 5%, Afar 5%

GOVERNMENT: Transitional regime

CURRENCY: Nakfa = 100 cents